The Price of Flexibility

What PMEs value, what employers weigh, and where they meet

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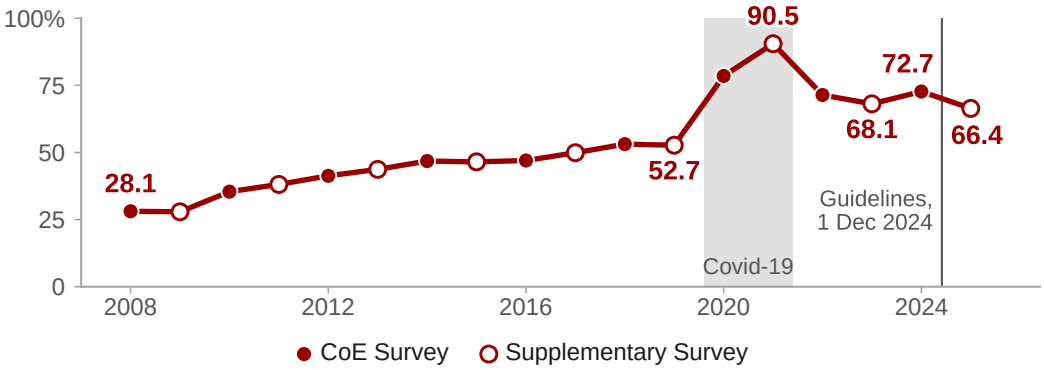
Joint work with the Singapore National Employers Federation (SNEF)

Preliminary findings for tripartite discussion | January 2027

SNEF
SINGAPORE NATIONAL EMPLOYERS FEDERATION

SMU
SINGAPORE MANAGEMENT UNIVERSITY

Flexible work is mainstream now



Share of establishments (25+ staff, incl. public sector) offering a scheduled FWA.

Source: MRSD, MOM (Jun 2026).

▸ Guidelines

Remote work: Singapore and abroad

Definition	Population	Country	Value	Year
Days worked from home last week (6+ hours)	Full-time workers aged 20–64 with a college degree	Average of 40 countries	1.2	2024/25
		Singapore	**1.2**	2024/25
		United Kingdom	1.8	2024/25
		United States	1.6	2024/25
		Japan	0.7	2024/25
		South Korea	0.5	2024/25

Same survey and question in every country. Aksoy et al. 2025 (EconPol Policy Brief 73, Fig. 1).

▸ Studies ▸ Benchmarks

The open problem is fit, not whether a process exists

Arrangement fit

Aggregate provision masks which arrangements are available, and whether they fit the worker and the role.

Two sides, measured together

Worker value and employers' hiring reservations are rarely measured together.

Barriers

Career, information and redesign barriers can block mutually beneficial use.

Which arrangements create common ground, for which roles, and what blocks adoption?

▸ Guidelines

What is known, and what this study adds

	Known so far	This study adds
Workers	WFH is worth **4–8%** of pay (Singapore 4.8%, asked directly in a 27-country survey). Other FWAs not measured.	**Six more FWAs** besides WFH
Employers	One study, in Poland, on WFH only: employers expect a **21%** wage cut, workers give up **2.9%**.	Employers' values, **measured the same way** as workers'
Singapore	Surveys cover FWA use and provision; the one value estimate is for WFH only (4.8%). **No study prices other FWAs, or the employer side.**	**FWA values estimated for Singapore**, both sides on one scale: the **gap**

References: Mas & Pallais 2017; Maestas et al. 2023; Aksoy et al. 2022; Lewandowski et al. 2023; MRSD 2024; SNEF–SUSS 2025.

▸ Studies ▸ Benchmarks ▸ Trials

Key findings

WFH

12–37 points

gap between what employers expect to cut pay by and what PMEs would give up, for 1–2 days, 3–4 days and fully remote WFH

Common ground

No gap

for the compressed week: PMEs would give up about 7% of pay, employers expect about 11%; the difference is not significant

Hurdles

49% vs 3%

employers' pay cut for 1–2 WFH days where most roles need on-site presence vs where few do; stated concerns do not reliably change it

Juniors have less access and know the Guidelines least; 45% of PMEs fear a career penalty.

Pay in % of monthly pay, stated choices from unweighted online panels; preliminary.

▸ Limits ▸ Robustness

We surveyed 1,020 PMEs and 465 employers

1,020 PMEs

Professionals, managers, executives: citizens and PRs in or seeking such roles

Online panels, unweighted

Fielded 4–21 Aug 2026

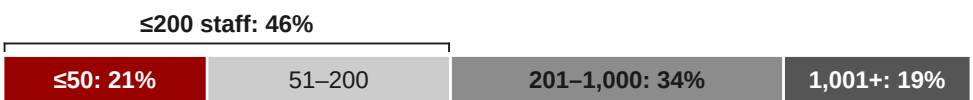
465 employer respondents

People involved in PME hiring or manpower decisions

Online panel, unweighted

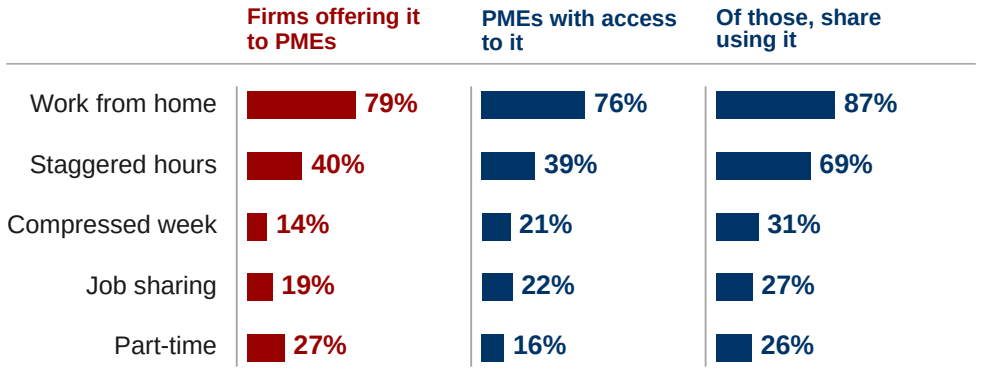
Fielded 12 Aug–21 Oct 2026

Employer respondents' firms, by staff size



Sample

WFH is the common FWA; the others reach fewer PMEs



Even where available, only 3 in 10 use the compressed week, job sharing or part-time.

With access: PMEs who say it is available to them or already use it.

▸ Pathways ▸ Numbers

Both sides chose between the same kinds of options

PMEs choose a job

Attribute	Job Offer A	Job Offer B
Monthly salary	**S$2,550/month**	**S$3,300/month**
Work location	1–2 days WFH/week	Fully remote (5 days WFH)
Work schedule	Staggered hours	Fixed hours (9am–6pm)
Workload	Full-time (35–44 hours/week)	
Job security	Moderate (10–30% chance)	
Workplace culture	Collaborative	
Commute time for onsite days	Moderate (15–45 minutes)	

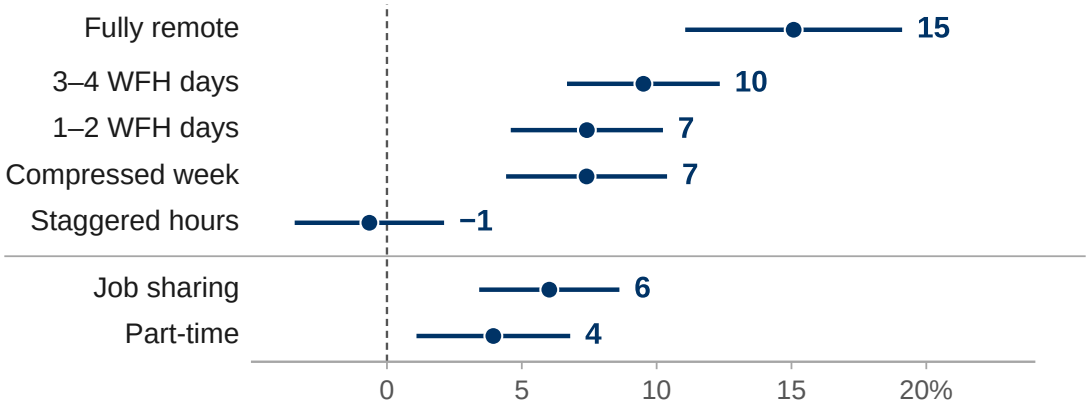
Employers choose a hire

Attribute	Candidate A	Candidate B
Monthly salary	**S$4,500/month**	**S$5,500/month**
Work location	3–4 days WFH/week	1–2 days WFH/week
Work schedule	Compressed 4-day week	Fixed hours (9am–6pm)
Workload	Full-time (35–44 hours/week)	
Retention risk	Low (<10% turnover)	
Workplace culture	Hierarchical	

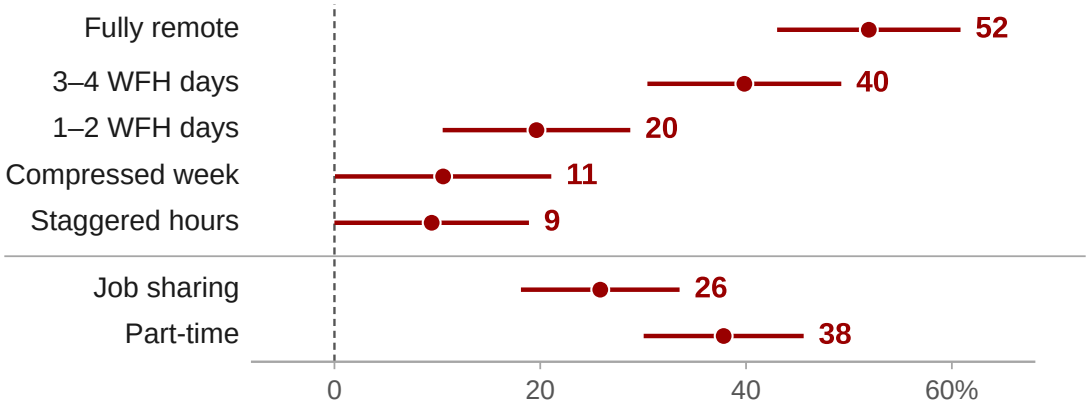
Two attributes differ in each choice; which ones, and their levels, are randomized. From six choices each, we estimate the **% of pay** each side would give up or require.

▸ Choice cards ▸ Sample

PMEs place a high value on remote work

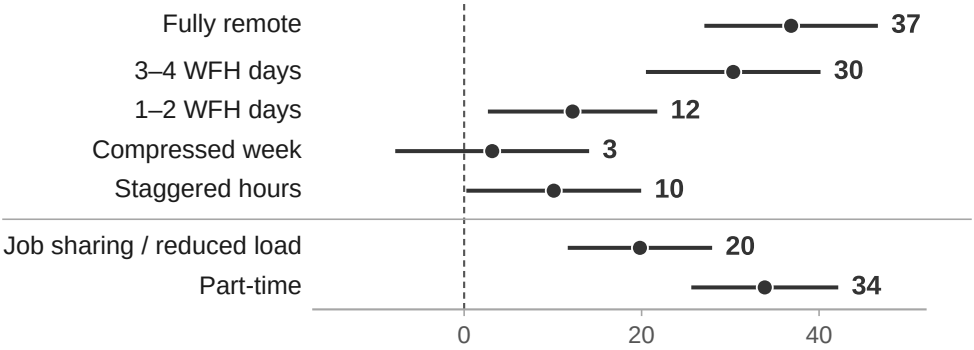


Employers expect a pay cut, biggest for fully remote work



Numbers | Checks | By size

The two sides' values meet only for the compressed week

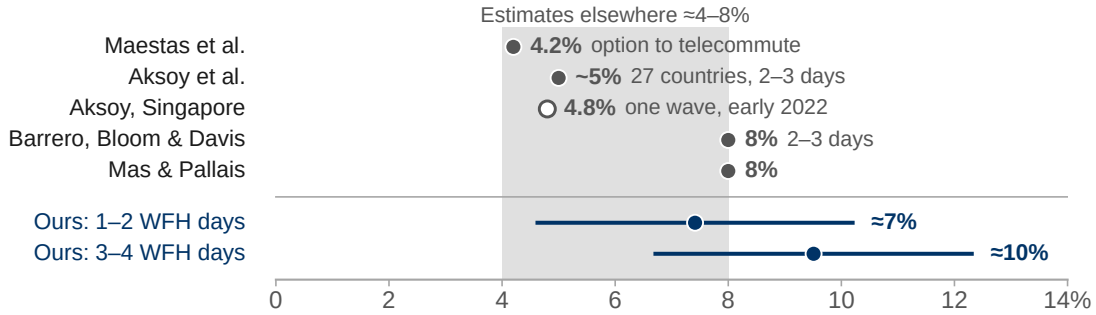


Only for the compressed week is the gap small and not significant (about 3 points). For WFH, employers expect a pay cut 12 to 37 points larger than PMEs would accept.

Gap: pay cut employers require minus pay PMEs would give up, in points of pay, with 95% intervals.

▸ Numbers ▸ Raw choices

Our WFH values are at or above estimates abroad



Abroad, workers give up about 4–8% of pay for WFH (two studies asked about 2–3 days); in Poland, employers expect a 21% wage cut, workers 2.9%.

Not like-for-like: populations, methods and definitions differ. Barrero, Bloom & Davis: *The Evolution of Work from Home* (JEP 2023).

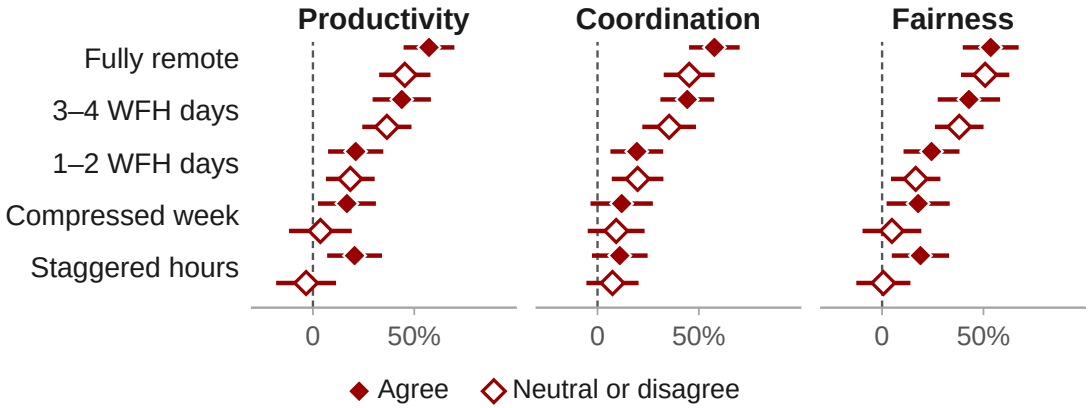
▸ Studies ▸ Trials

Employers’ biggest challenge: productivity, coordination, fairness



▸ Employer view

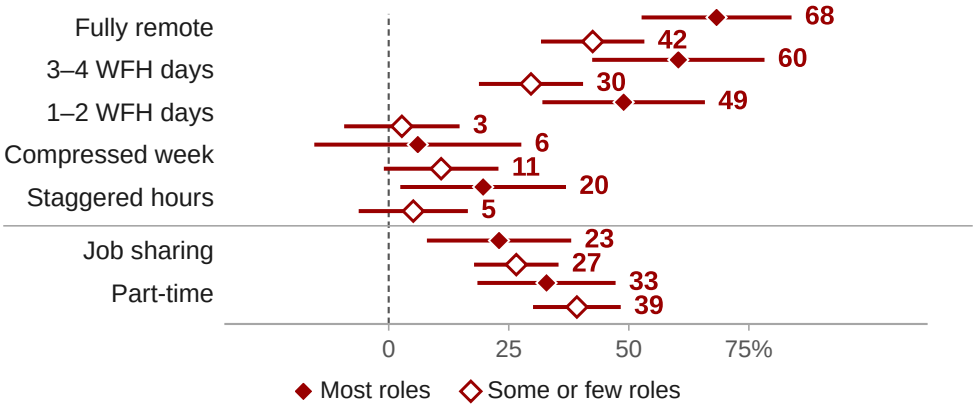
Employers' main concerns do not reliably change the pay cut



Agree = 4–5 of 5; neutral or disagree = 1–3.

▸ Four concerns ▸ Employer view

On-site needs raise the WFH pay cut, not the others



Staggered hours, the compressed week, job sharing and part-time show no such difference. Early evidence only.

All splits | Other traits | Employer view

All levels value WFH alike, but juniors have less access

Access and awareness

Share of employed PMEs



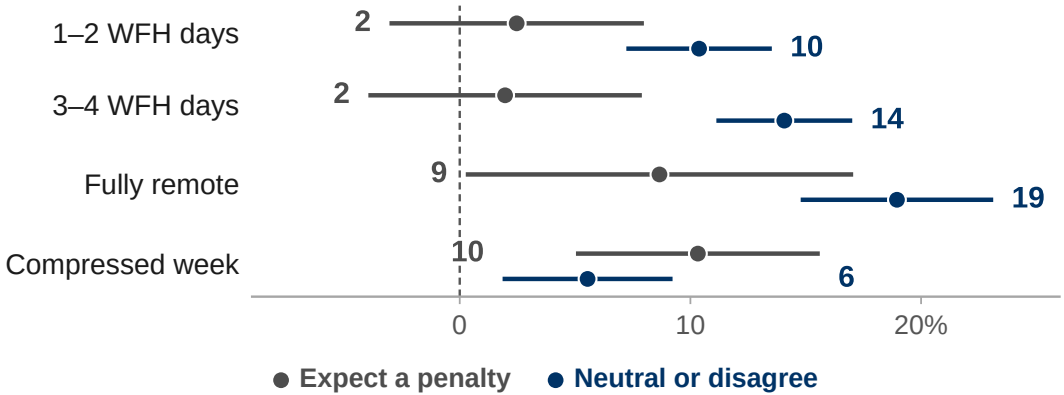
Pay given up for WFH

% of monthly pay



▸ By level ▸ Access ▸ Awareness

PMEs who fear a career penalty give up much less pay for WFH



Expect a penalty: agree (4–5 of 5) that flexible hours would hurt their career; neutral or disagree = 1–3.

Career risk | Use | Value

What we found

Values	PMEs would give up **7–15%** of pay for WFH, more with each extra day; employers expect **20–52%** cuts, a gap of 12–37 points
Common ground	Only the **compressed week** shows no significant gap (about 7% vs 11%); 15% of firms offer it
Employers	Name **productivity, coordination and fairness** as hurdles, but these do not reliably change the pay cut; **on-site needs** do (49% vs 3% for 1–2 days)
PMEs	Juniors have **less access** (80% vs 94%) and know the Guidelines least; 45% fear a career penalty, and those who do give up much less pay for WFH

▸ Limits ▸ Robustness

Policy directions

Direction	Based on	How to track
A Pilot the compressed week (same hours over four days) in volunteer firms, with a comparison group	No significant pay gap (about 7% vs 11%); 15% of firms offer it, 21% of PMEs have it	Take-up, quits, coverage
B Add a role-by-role check of on-site need to FWA guidance; start with 1–2 WFH days in roles that need none	Employers' pay cut for 1–2 days: 49% where most roles need presence, 3% where few do	Firms offering 1–2 days
C Reach juniors and support HR: put what is on offer and how use is appraised into company policy; brief managers on requests	Access 80% (junior) vs 94% (senior); know the Guidelines 29% vs 77%; 45% fear a career penalty	Juniors' access, familiarity, career worry

Stated choices from online panels; employer splits are preliminary.

▸ Pilot checklist

Next steps for our research

1 Match firms and their staff

Link willing firms to a few of their own staff, who consent directly.

Compare what firms offer and expect with what their staff have and value.

2 Track over time

Re-survey every six months and record hiring and departures.

Test whether stated choices predict take-up and quits.

3 Test a manager guide

Give a guide on role-by-role on-site checks and handling requests to a random half of firms first.

Compare offering and request handling.

▸ Follow-up

Thank you

Questions and discussion

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Joint work with the Singapore National Employers Federation (SNEF)

▸ Backup index

Backup index: likely questions

Policy and practice

- Did the Guidelines change outcomes?
- Should FWA requests be legislated?
- Is this a burden for smaller firms?
- How would a compressed-week pilot run?
- Why do some PMEs not ask?
- Do all job levels have the same access?
- What next, and with whose consent?

The evidence

- Is the career risk real?
- Are reservations about roles or concerns?
- Is the compressed-week result a design artefact?

The study

- Do stated choices predict behaviour?

Full backup index | Summary | Thank you

Full backup index

Background
Studies · Benchmarks
Evidence abroad · Rules abroad
Pathways · Surveys
Guidelines

Data and design
Sample · Industries
Choice cards
Why not pay data · Estimation
Validity

PME values
All estimates · Numbers · Commute
Group differences
Gender · Age · Care
Role · Education · Size
Access · Users vs others

Employer values
Raw choices
All splits · Four concerns
Other traits · By respondent · Own view

Compressed week
Valued, rarely offered · Design
Flexi-load · Pilot checklist

Barriers
Career risk · Who expects it
Use by view · Value by view
By level · Awareness
Approvals · Request rate

Robustness
Summary · PMEs · Employers

Limits and directions
Limits · Follow-up
Direction A B C Draft survey items

Likely questions · Thank you

Studies behind the benchmarks and the question

Study	Setting	What it finds
Mas & Pallais (2017)	US call-centre applicants	Give up 8% of wages for the option to work from home
Aksoy et al. (2022)	27-country online survey (Singapore: n = 1,002, early 2022; about 90% tertiary)	One direct question on 2–3 WFH days; Singapore 4.8%, average 5.0%
Aksoy et al. (2025)	40-country online survey, full-time graduates (Singapore n = 419)	WFH 1.2 days a week on average; Singapore 1.2; lowest in Asia
Barrero, Bloom & Davis (2023)	US workers (SWAA)	Option to WFH 2–3 days a week worth 8% of pay on average
Maestas et al. (2023)	US workers	WFH worth about 4% of pay; own schedule about 9%
Lewandowski et al. (2023)	Poland, both sides	Workers give up 2.9%, employers expect a 21% wage cut (pooled)
Aum, Kim & Lee (2025)	3,026 Korean workers	Horizontal culture valued most; a precedent for pricing job attributes
Wang & Dong (2024)	Singapore, young unmarried workers	Flexible work raises fertility intentions, most for women and professionals
MRSD Conditions of Employment (2024)	Singapore firms; regressions	Larger, PMET-heavy firms offer more FWAs; better outcomes for flexi-hours and telework than part-time
SNEF–SUSS report (2025)	Singapore employers	Practices, benefits and drawbacks; no pay trade-offs

◂ Literature ◂ Estimates abroad

Backup index

Evidence elsewhere: concerns and trials

- **Poland, two-sided experiment:** workers give up 2.9% of pay for remote work; employers expect a 21% wage cut, mostly for lost productivity (Lewandowski et al., IZA DP 16041, 2023; hybrid and fully remote pooled). ILR Review (2026) version: gaps $\approx$ 5% (hybrid), 25% (fully remote).
- **Randomised hybrid trial** (two days a week; 1,612 graduates, one Chinese firm): quits fell by one-third over six months; over two years, reviews were unaffected and promotions showed no statistically significant difference; managers' productivity view: -2.6% to $+1.0\%$ (Bloom, Han & Liang, Nature 2024; co-author J. Liang co-founded Trip.com).
- **Singapore firms offering scheduled FWAs:** 69.5% report better engagement, 65.9% retention, 59.9% productivity (employer-reported, mid-2024; MRSD).
- **Fully remote:** evidence is mixed and job-dependent; several studies find lower productivity, partly reflecting who selects into remote jobs (Barrero, Bloom & Davis 2023; Emanuel & Harrington 2024).

◂ Literature ◂ Directions

Backup index

Backup B4

Most FWAs come via policy or request

PMEs: how FWA was set up (N = 869)	%	Employers (N = 465)	%
Company-wide policy (automatic)	43	Written policy: all firms	72
Individual request	30	... 200 or fewer staff	67
Informal, with manager	18	... 201–1,000 staff	75
Negotiated in contract	5	... 1,001 or more staff	80
Don't know	5	... size test (p)	.055
		Got formal requests: with policy[1]	66
		... without policy	22

[1] Firms aware of the Guidelines.

◂ Practice ◂ Barriers

Backup index

Backup B5

Official surveys: demand, provision and penalties

Required and provided, 2024

32% / 23% / 21%
required scheduled tele-working, flexible hours, choice of days off

72% / 67% / 75%
of those who required each were provided with it

Felt penalised for taking up FWAs, 2020

9%
of employees felt penalised

34 / 29 / 29
of them: fewer training opportunities / reduced benefits / passed over for promotion

Sources: MRSD, Report on Employees' Working Conditions (May 2026); Work-Life Harmony Report 2020.

◂ Practice ◂ Career concerns

Backup index

Backup B6

The Guidelines: process, not outcome

1. Request	→ 2. Proper consideration	→ 3. Written decision
In writing by default	On business needs	Within 2 months; reasons if declined

In effect from 1 Dec 2024 for employees past probation. A significant cost burden or customer needs can be business grounds to decline; a preference for face time, or refusing to avoid similar requests from others, cannot. TAFEP takes an educational approach, guiding employers to comply (MOM, 2026).

MOM indicators, 2024 data: not one funnel; definitions differ

84.5%
who needed a scheduled FWA got one they needed

≈ 94%
of requests approved; base not defined

18.5%
of those in need asked formally; 26.3% informally

Full-time residents aged 25–64, almost entirely before the Guidelines; MOM reads the gap as "frictions", not employer resistance. Firms need not report requests to MOM. Establishments (25+ staff) offering a scheduled FWA: 72.7% (Jun 2024), 66.4% (Jun 2025; another MOM survey; not attributed to the Guidelines).

Sources: Tripartite Guidelines (2024); MRSD (2026); MOM PQ replies; COS 2026.

◂ Question ◂ Motivation

Backup index

FWA request rules elsewhere

- **Singapore:** tripartite guidelines on the process, not the outcome; TAFEP takes an educational approach.
- **Great Britain:** statutory right to request from day one (since Apr 2024); decision within 2 months; refusal only on eight listed business reasons; a tribunal if a request is not handled reasonably, not merely if refused. Employment Rights Act 2025 changes due in 2027.
- **Australia:** eligible employees (e.g. parents, carers, 55+); written reply within 21 days; refusal only on reasonable business grounds; the Fair Work Commission can arbitrate and, as a last resort, order it granted. **New Zealand:** any employee; reply within 1 month; eight listed grounds; disputes cover process only. In both, most requests are informal.
- **Why guidelines here:** the Workgroup judged legislation risks an acrimonious workplace culture; at COS 2026, MOM called legislating the Guidelines, with a presumptive FWA right for parents of young children, too blunt.

Sources: MOM COS 2026, FAQ; Workgroup report (2024); gov.uk/flexible-working; Fair Work Act 2009; Employment Relations Act 2000 (NZ).

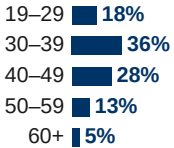
Who answered

PMEs (n = 1,020)

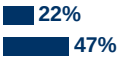
Gender



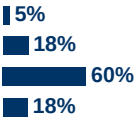
Age



Role

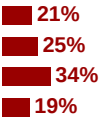


Education

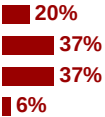


Employers (n = 465)

Firm size (staff)



Role



Design Data

Backup index

Backup B9

Respondents span the main industries



% of each sample; sorted by PME share.

Employed PMEs (n = 1,004), employers (n = 465). Employer industry cells hold 8 to 77 firms, too few for industry estimates.

Data

Backup index

Backup B10

Nearly the same cards on both sides

Attribute	PMEs (job offers)	Employers (candidates)
Salary	Own salary $\times$ multiplier	Latest PME-hire salary $\times$ multiplier
Location	Onsite; 1–2 WFH days a week; 3–4 days; fully remote	Same
Schedule	Fixed 9am–6pm; staggered; compressed 4-day week (same hours, longer days)	Same
Workload	Full-time (35–44 h); *job sharing (4 days)*; part-time ($<$35 h)	Full-time; *reduced load (4 days)*; part-time
Risk	Job loss (low / moderate / high)	Turnover (low $<$10% / moderate / high $>$20%)
Other	Culture; commute	Culture
Design	6 forced choices between 2 options; each pair differs in salary and two attributes, the rest held at the respondent's own practice. Pay differs by 17–33% between the options.	

Employers were told both candidates are equally qualified.

◂ Design

Pay data cannot price flexibility

Current arrangement (vs onsite / full-time)	Observed pay difference, %	Value in the experiment, % of pay
1–2 days WFH	+37	≈7
3–4 days WFH	+36	≈10
Fully remote[1]	+42	≈15
Part-time	−53	≈4

[1] Experiment: vs onsite with a long commute. Grey = indicative.

Log current pay on current arrangement, with controls (N = 991 employed PMEs).

◂ Design

Backup index

Backup B12

How we turn choices into values

Illustrative choice task

Scenario 1 of 6

	Job Offer A	Job Offer B
Monthly pay	**+10%** vs own pay	**–10%** vs own pay
Work location	Fully onsite	1–2 days WFH
Work schedule	Fixed hours	Compressed 4-day week

Workload, Job security, Workplace culture, Commute time: same for A and B (your current job)

How values are calculated

1. Choose A or B, six times
2. Estimate how pay and each FWA shift choices
3. Translate it into the **% of pay** each side would give up or require (indicative)

▸ Validity

Backup index

Backup B13

Do stated choices predict real choices?

Maestas et al. (AER 2023)	US workers, up to 3 years on: 977 of 1,738 (56%) matched; kept vs lost an amenity: +4.1 pp (1% level); gained: +1.7 pp (n.s.)
Wiswall & Zafar (QJE 2018)	NYU students, about 4 years on (59 working): 6 of 6 links to actual jobs with the expected sign, 3 significant at 5%
Mas & Pallais (AER 2017)	Call-centre applicants: WFH 8.4% of pay, survey (reweighted to field commute times) vs 7.8%, field; scheduling 2.5% vs 2.8%
Hainmueller et al. (PNAS 2015)	Swiss voters: paired conjoint (best of 5 designs) within 2 pp of referendum effects on average (21 effects); levels missed (21% vs 37% rejection)
Health DCE meta-analyses	Opting in predicted well; opting out weakly (pooled specificity 34–52%)

- **Rankings hold best:** direction right and, in one direct test, relative size; our ranking is the firmest result.
- **Levels less so:** rates predicted less well, money values mixed; our % of pay values are indicative.
- **Our design:** one cross-section; pay gaps of 17–33% only; no link yet to behaviour.

No cited study validates employer hiring choices of this form;
our follow-up addresses only part of that gap.

◂ Estimation ◂ Robustness

Backup index

Backup B14

All PME estimates, % of pay

Level (vs base)	% of pay	95% CI	Status
1–2 days WFH (onsite)	≈7	5–10	Direction robust
3–4 days WFH (onsite)	≈10	7–12	Direction robust
Fully remote (onsite, long commute)	≈15	11–19	≈12 vs moderate, ≈8 vs short commute
Staggered hours (fixed hours)	≈0	−3 to 2	Robust: about zero
Compressed week (fixed hours)	≈7	4–10	Direction robust
Job sharing (full-time)	≈6	3–9	Hours change: not a price
Part-time (full-time)	≈4	1–7	Hours change: not a price
Low job-loss risk (high)	≈5	0–10	*not robust*: ≈2 (n.s.) with position term; ≈9 excl. same-side
Short commute (long commute)	≈8	3–13	Context only

Base level in brackets. N = 1,020. Grey = indicative.

Fully remote is compared with onsite work and a long commute (commute).

◂ PMEs

Offering, use and pay terms: numbers

Arrangement	Firms offer, %	PMEs with access, %	PMEs use, %	Use, if available, %	PMEs give up, %	Employers require, %	Gap, points
Compressed week	14	21	6	31 [25, 38]	7 [4, 10]	11 [0, 21]	3 [−8, 14], n.s.
1–2 days WFH	79	76	66	87 [85, 89]	7 [5, 10]	20 [11, 29]	12 [3, 22]
3–4 days WFH					10 [7, 12]	40 [30, 49]	30 [21, 40]
Fully remote					15 [11, 19]	52 [43, 61]	37 [27, 47]
Staggered hours	40	39	27	69 [65, 74]	−1 [−3, 2]	9 [0, 19]	10 [0, 20]
Job sharing / reduced load	19	22	6	27 [21, 33]	6 [3, 9]	26 [18, 34]	20 [12, 28]
Part-time	27	16	4	26 [20, 33]	4 [1, 7]	38 [30, 46]	34 [26, 42]

Access: available or already used. Use, if available: share using among PMEs with access. Offer, access and use refer to any WFH (first WFH row). 95% CIs; n.s. = not significant at 5%.

◂ Practice ◂ Two sides

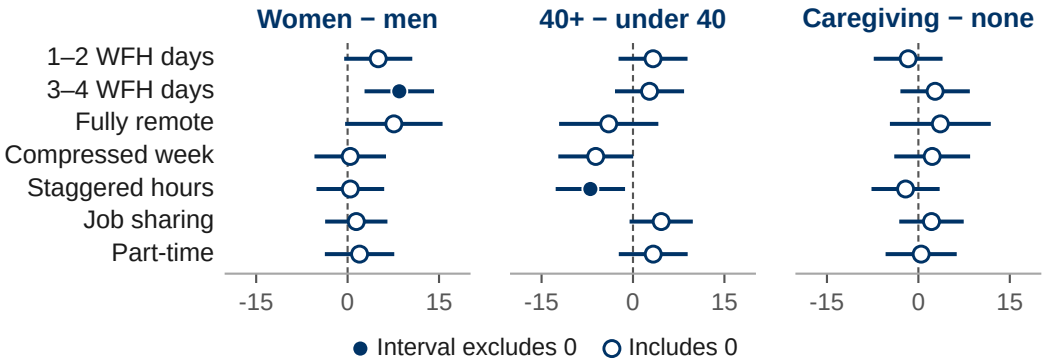
Backup index

Fully remote valued against any commute

Fully remote, compared with onsite work with . . .	% of pay given up [95% CI]
a long commute (>45 min) (main estimate)	15.1 [11.1, 19.1]
a moderate commute (15–45 min)	12.2 [9.0, 15.5]
a short commute (<15 min)	7.5 [2.9, 12.1]

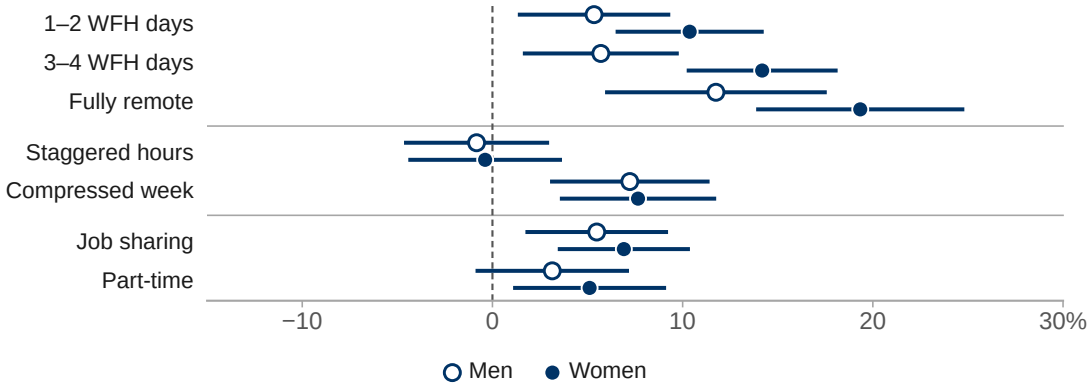
◂ PMEs

Women give up more for WFH; little else differs



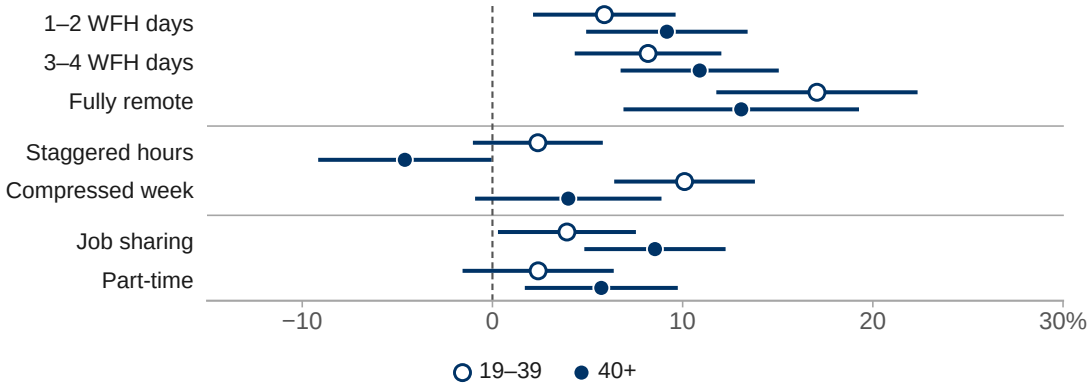
Women give up more for WFH (clearly for 3–4 days); PMEs aged 40+ less for staggered hours. Other differences are small or imprecise.

Estimates by gender



PME groups

Estimates by age

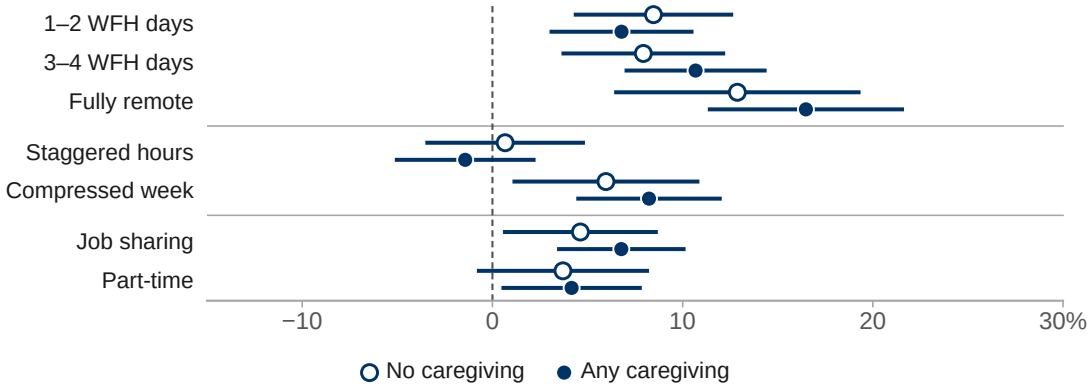


PME groups

Backup index

Backup B20

Estimates by caregiving

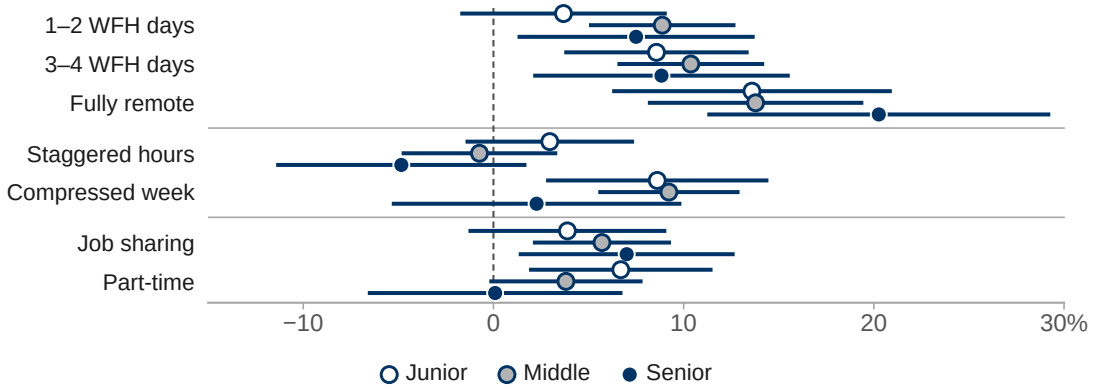


PME groups

Backup index

Backup B21

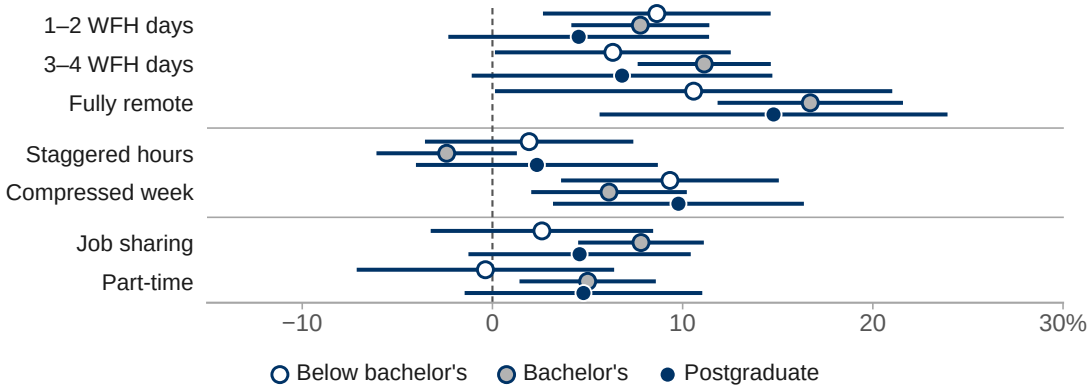
Estimates by role level



PME groups

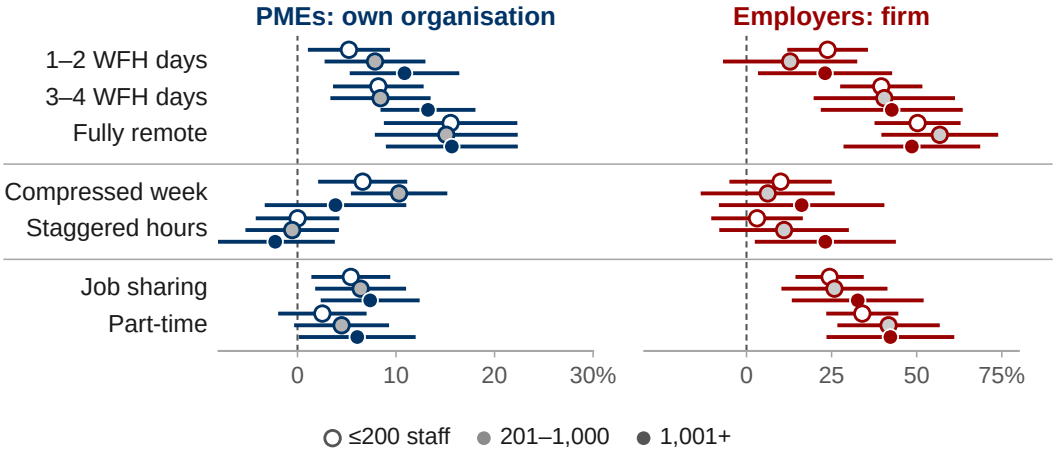
Backup index

Estimates by education



PME groups

No clear difference by organisation size



No difference between size groups is significant at 5% (0 of 21 comparisons on each side).

◂ PMEs ◂ Employers

Valued more where offered? Not robust

Arrangement	Offered	Not offered	Difference	Take-up, %
WFH (any level)		valued equally either way		87
Staggered hours	≈0	≈−2	n.s. (p = .60)	69
Compressed week	≈15	≈6	+9 (p = .004), *not robust*[1]	31
Compressed, separate slopes[1]	–	–	+5.5 [−4.4, 15.4] (p = .27)	
Job sharing	≈7	≈6	n.s. (p = .82)	27
Part-time	≈15	≈2	+13 (p <.001), *not robust*[2]	26

% of pay, one pay slope for both groups. [1] *Not robust*: not significant with separate pay slopes. [2]Not re-estimated; treated as not robust. N = 983 employed PMEs. Take-up = use among those with access. Grey = indicative.

Significant only under a common pay slope; PMEs with access are less pay-sensitive (log-pay coefficient 2.79 vs 4.70).

◂ Puzzle ◂ Groups

Backup index

Backup B25

Current users value part-time and staggered hours more

Arrangement	Users (n)	Non-users give up	Users give up	Difference [95% CI]
1–2 days WFH	382	8	6	−2 [−7, 3]
3–4 days WFH	154	9	10	1 [−6, 8]
Fully remote	130	15	18	3 [−5, 10]
Compressed week	65	7	14	7 [−2, 17]
Staggered hours	273	−3	3	**6 [1, 11]**
Job sharing	60	6	6	0 [−12, 12]
Part-time	43	3	17	**14 [3, 25]**

Users give up more for part-time (14 points) and staggered hours (6), but not for WFH.

Pay given up, % of pay; difference = users minus non-users. Bold: the 95% interval excludes 0.

◂ Current use

Backup index

Backup B26

Raw choices, before any model

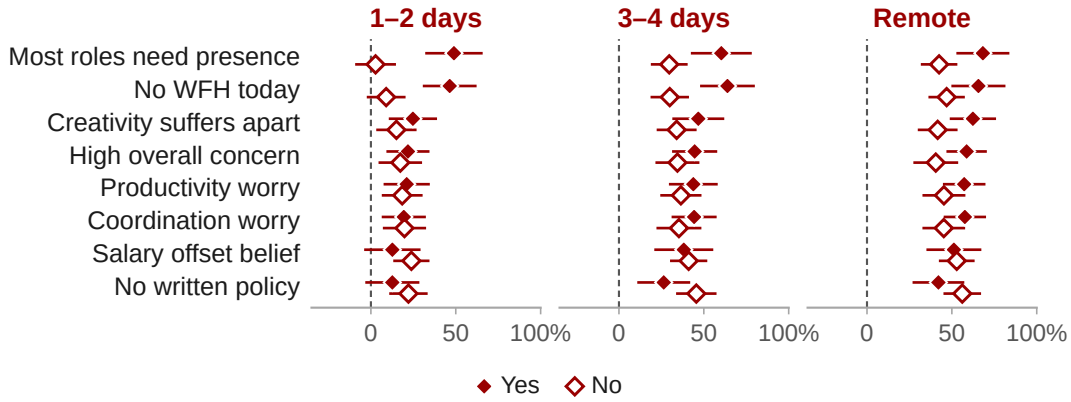
	PMEs: flexible job		Employers: flexible hire	
% choosing it (n)	**paid less**	**paid more**	**cheaper**	**dearer**
1–2 days WFH	27 (350)	88 (170)	46 (203)	38 (104)
3–4 days WFH	23 (407)	81 (167)	36 (181)	32 (82)
Fully remote	43 (320)	80 (116)	36 (123)	10 (41)
Staggered hours	22 (921)	76 (334)	62 (374)	–
Compressed week	24 (768)	87 (122)	58 (252)	35 (46)
Reduced load / job sharing	25 (641)	80 (458)	58 (285)	29 (170)
Part-time	28 (691)	80 (223)	39 (262)	24 (203)
Chose the better-paid option	75 (6,120)		57 (2,790)	
Better on both other features, paid less	28 (2,563)		–	

◂ Two sides ◂ Employers

Backup index

Backup B27

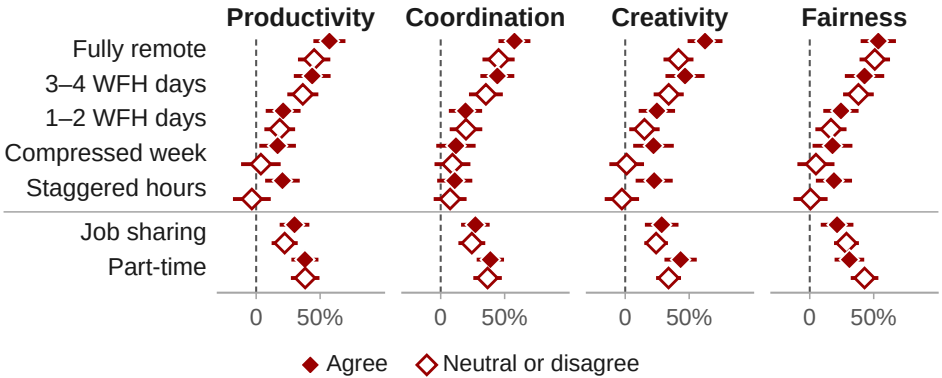
Employer pay cut by roles, concerns and policy: WFH



Yes = as labelled (agree = 4–5 of 5); no = otherwise. Each group has 116–349 firms.

On-site needs

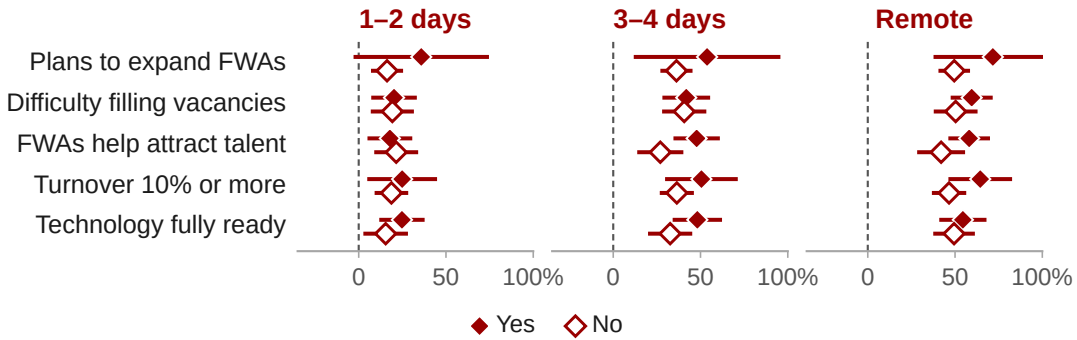
Four concerns: common; creativity shows the clearest signal



Agree = 4–5 of 5; neutral or disagree = 1–3.

Concerns

Employer pay cut by hiring pressure and readiness: WFH



Yes = as labelled (agree = 4–5 of 5); no = otherwise. Each group has 106–330 firms.

On-site needs

Employers' pay cut by respondent role: owner, HR, hiring manager



HR expects larger cuts than line or hiring managers for 3–4 days, remote, job sharing and part-time; 5 of 21 comparisons significant at 5%.

Employers | All splits

Backup index

Backup B31

Employers: talent upside, practical hurdles

Biggest FWA challenge

% of employers ◇ ≤200 staff (n = 215)

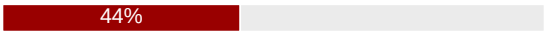


Other: 5%.

FWAs help attract, retain talent (agree)



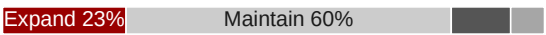
Unfair if frontline can't have FWAs (agree)



Hard to fill PME vacancies (past year)



12-month FWA plan — reduce 11% · unsure 6%



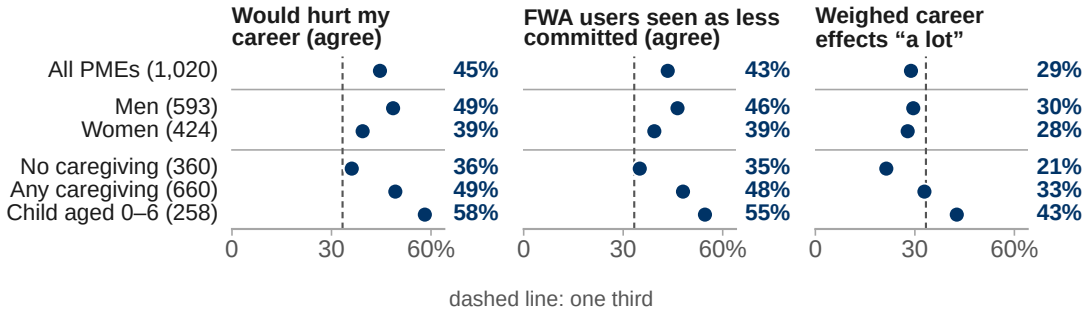
Tech-ready for remote work — not ready 7%



Agree = 4–5 of 5. Compressed-week offering rises with firm size (11, 16, 24%; p = .013); pay cut by size: By size.

◂ Challenges ◂ Concerns

Over a third of surveyed PMEs expect a career penalty



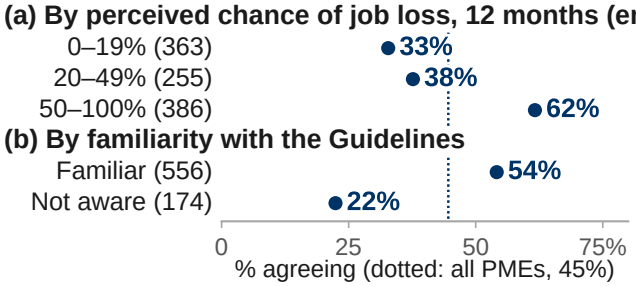
Agree = 4–5 of 5; neutral or disagree = 1–3: an expected penalty, not a reported setback. Who expects it.

◂ Barriers ◂ Why PMEs

Backup index

Backup B33

Who expects a career penalty?



(c) Formal request reported (employed, aware)

Expecting a penalty is associated with **+15 pp [9, 20]** after controls.

Full approval: no detectable difference (p = .44).

(c) Request item partly misread; asking may shape the belief.

Job-loss chance: a relative index, not a probability. Associations, not causes.
(b) Gap about halves with formal requests held fixed.

Expecting a penalty is more common among those who rate job loss as likely and among those unaware of the Guidelines. Associations, not causes.

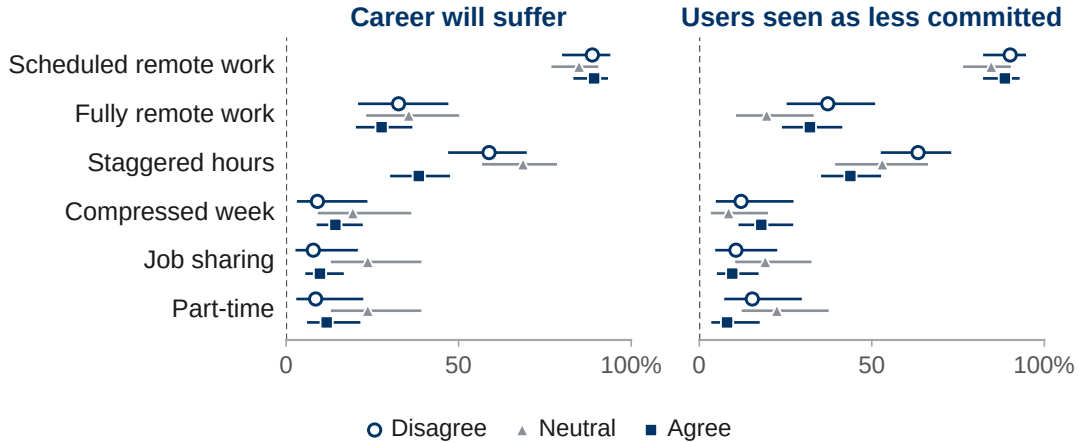
Agree = 4–5 of 5; neutral or disagree = 1–3. Job loss: self-rated 12-month chance. Chart.

◂ Barriers ◂ Career concerns

Backup index

Backup B34

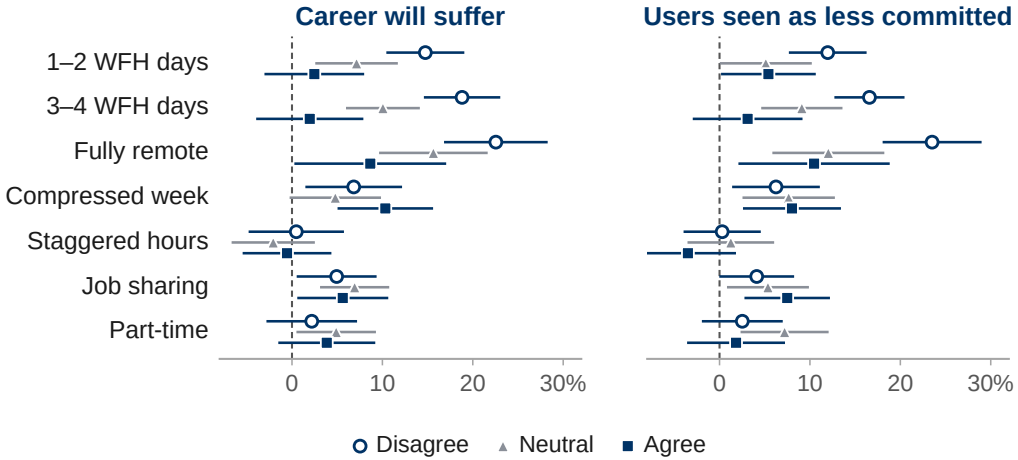
Use of the arrangement, by career worry and stigma



Share using, among PMEs with the arrangement available; 95% CI. Disagree = 1–2, neutral = 3, agree = 4–5. Career: “working shorter or more flexible hours would negatively affect my career”. Stigma: “users are seen as less committed”.

Career concerns

Pay given up, by career worry and stigma



Disagree = 1–2, neutral = 3, agree = 4–5.

Career concerns

Access, use and career worry by job level

	Junior	Middle	Senior
At least one of the five FWAs available	80%	85%	94%
Using at least one	66%	72%	80%
Use, among those with access	82%	84%	85%
Know the Guidelines' key provisions	29%	52%	77%
Expect flexible work to hurt their career	36%	45%	52%

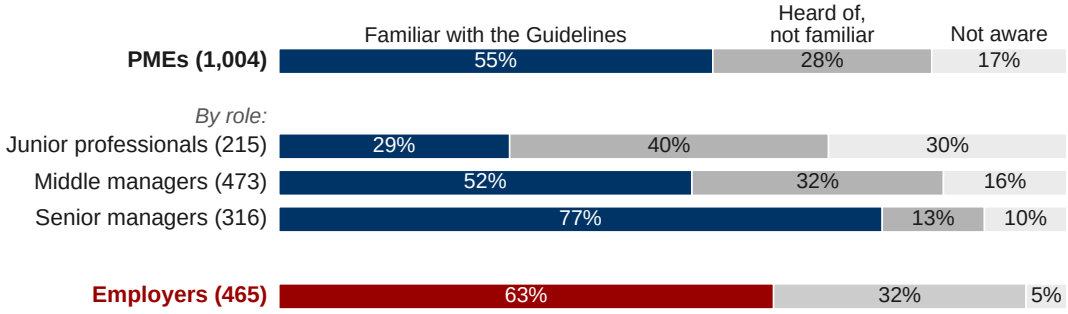
Employed PMEs (n = 215, 473, 316). Five FWAs: WFH, staggered hours, compressed week, job sharing, part-time.

◂ Levels ◂ By level

Backup index

Backup B37

Awareness is wide but shallow



PMEs: employed (n). Unweighted.
PAP–NTUC survey's 58% aware: not comparable.

PAP Women's Wing–NTUC survey (online, Nov–Dec 2025): 58% aware; 29% know where to turn if a request is denied.

Barriers

Same process, two vantage points

PMEs reporting a formal request

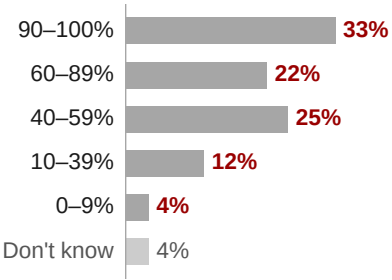
Reported outcome, %



Unweighted.

Employers: share of requests approved

(n = 244)



MOM, for comparison (definitions differ): ≈94% approved (2024 data, almost entirely before the Guidelines). After use, ≈6% of resident FWA users reported a career setback (2025): experience, not PMEs' expectation.

Different questions: PMEs report their own request; employers, their firm's approval share. Excluding automatic FWAs, 6.9% of PMEs' requests were declined (why). No before-and-after: we cannot say whether the Guidelines changed outcomes.

Barriers

Backup index

Why no headline request rate

Base	n	Made a formal request, %
Employed and aware of the Guidelines	832	65.7
All employed (not aware = no request)	1,004	54.5
FWA automatic by company policy	318	72.3

“Formal” was undefined and there was no “automatic” option.

Barriers

Backup index

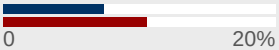
Backup B40

The compressed week: valued, rarely offered

Both sides: about the same

7%

vs 11%

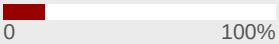


of pay: PMEs give up vs employers require

Few firms offer it

1 in 7

15%



of surveyed firms offer it to PMEs

Goes with a written FWA policy

17.8%

vs 8.6%

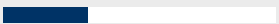


of firms with / without a written policy offer it

Take-up where available

1 in 3

31%



of PMEs with access use it

PMEs would give up about 7% of pay for it, yet few firms offer it.
A voluntary, evaluated pilot is the next step.

▸ Offering ▸ Pilot checklist

Backup index

Backup B41

Compressed week: design balance, offering, use

Design: usually the cheaper option

The lower-paid option in 83% of PME and 92% of employer pairs.

% chosen if	cheaper	dearer
PMEs: compressed	27.5	85.5
PMEs: others	24.9	75.1
Firms: compressed	66	35[c]
Firms: others	55	45

PMEs: consistent with a positive value at either price. **Firms:** mixed; "no detectable penalty" rests mainly on cheaper candidates. Operating costs unmeasured: pilot checklist.

Surveyed firms offering it (71 of 465)

Trait	% offering	p
Written policy: yes vs no	17.8 vs 8.6	.014
Offers part-time	25.5 vs 10.4	$<.001$
Offers job sharing	32.4 vs 7.0	$<.001$
Worried about productivity	18.9 vs 11.3	.024
Hard to hire	16.0 vs 14.4	.62
Size: $\leq$200 / 201–1,000 / 1,001+	11.2 / 15.6 / 24.4	.013

Surveyed PMEs: access 21%; take-up 31%.

Associations, not causes; a written policy may follow offering. [c]46 pairs.

◂ Compressed week ◂ Directions

Backup index

Backup B42

Flexi-load: mostly pay for hours

Model-dependent; not a pay recommendation and not a main finding.

	Reduced load / job sharing[1]	Part-time
PMEs: pay given up, % of pay (95% CI)	≈6 (3–9)	≈4 (1–7)
Employers: pay cut required, %	≈26	38
Gap, % of pay	≈20	≈34
Employed PMEs using it, %	6	4
Take-up with access, %[2]	27	26

[1] Employers saw “reduced load”, PMEs “job sharing”. [2] Among employed PMEs with access. Grey = indicative.

◂ Two sides ◂ Directions

Backup index

A compressed-week pilot: checklist

Design

- Same hours, four longer days; pay and leave unchanged
- Legal, contract and collective-agreement review
- Voluntary for firms and staff; reversible without penalty
- Eligibility; fairness to staff who cannot join

Safeguards

- Service and coverage plan
- Fatigue, safety and care hours
- Workload spillovers
- Appraisal by output, not presence

Evaluation

- Outcomes: output, operating costs, coverage, retention, take-up, worker experience
- Stop and scale criteria agreed with the partners in advance
- Independent evaluation with a comparison group; worker data only with consent, never for appraisal

Why a pilot: most promising common-ground test; evidence moderate; operating costs unmeasured.

To agree: number of firms, duration, comparison group, funder, data access, report-back date.

Possible leads: SNEF with volunteer firms; NTUC co-designs safeguards; TAFEP guidance.

◂ Compressed week ◂ Directions

Backup index

Rankings are more credible than levels

Check	Concern	Result
Salary outliers; 1% trim	Monthly salary outside S$2,000–50,000	Arrangements: about 1 point or less, both sides
Same-side answers	Inattention	PMEs: about 1 point or less; employers: up to 2 points
Position term	Left-option bias	Arrangements: at most 2 points, both sides
Version clusters	Only 60 choice situations	Holds, except employer staggered hours (p = .15)
Rank pay model	How pay enters	Fits about as well on both sides; same ranking

The rankings hold under every check;
the exact % of pay values are less certain.

▸ Validity ▸ Checks

PME values hold in every sample

	Main	Excl. outliers	1% trim	Excl. same-side	Position term	Version CI
N	1,020	891	1,007	947	1,020	1,020
1–2 days WFH	≈7.4	≈7.4	≈7.4	≈6.5	≈7.9	5–10
3–4 days WFH	≈9.5	≈10.2	≈9.5	≈9.1	≈10.0	5–14
Fully remote	≈15.1	≈14.8	≈14.9	≈14.8	≈15.8	11–19
Compressed week	≈7.4	≈7.6	≈7.4	≈8.2	≈6.7	4–11
Staggered hours	≈−0.7	≈−0.6	≈−0.8	≈−0.5	≈0.6	−5–3
Job sharing	≈6.0	≈6.3	≈6.3	≈5.5	≈5.9	3–9
Part-time	≈3.9	≈4.9	≈4.2	≈2.9	≈5.1	2–6

% of pay given up. Version CI: 95% CI clustered by survey version.

Outliers: monthly salary outside S$2,000–50,000. Same-side: always chose one side.

◂ Robustness ◂ PMEs

Backup index

Backup B46

Employer values hold in every sample

	Main	Excl. outliers	1% trim	Excl. same-side
N	465	460	458	446
1–2 days WFH	≈19.6	≈19.7	≈19.8	≈18.8
3–4 days WFH	≈39.8	≈39.7	≈39.6	≈39.0
Fully remote	≈51.9	≈52.0	≈52.2	≈50.4
Compressed week	≈10.6	≈10.8	≈10.1	≈8.8
Staggered hours	≈9.4	≈8.8	≈8.7	≈10.1
Reduced load	≈25.8	≈25.9	≈26.1	≈25.9
Part-time	≈37.8	≈37.5	≈37.4	≈36.2

% pay cut employers would require. Outliers: monthly salary outside S$2,000–50,000; same-side: always chose one side.

◂ Robustness ◂ Employers

Backup index

Backup B47

Limits in detail

Limit	What it means	Next step
Pay gaps 17–33%	% of pay is model-based; employers weakly pay-sensitive (cheaper won 57%)	A small-gap wave
60 design cells	10 versions $\times$ 6 tasks per side: intervals likely too narrow	Cluster by version
Compressed week	Cheaper in 83% (PME) and 92% (employer) of its pairs	Balance pay positions
Employer splits	Preliminary associations, asked after the choices	Ask these items before the choices
Employer task	A hire, not a staff request; not an operating cost	Pilots that record operations
Samples	Unweighted panels, mostly large firms	Items in MOM surveys
Request item	Misread; refusals among askers only; no why-not item	draft survey items

Also: stated choices (SNEF use known); no before-and-after; salaries outside S$2,000–50,000 were capped (129 of 1,020 PMEs, 5 of 465 employers); task-1 coding.

◂ Robustness

Backup index

Backup B48

Follow-up design, if supported

	Aim 1: do stated choices predict behaviour?	Aim 2: what changes in firms that adopt?
Outcomes	FWA take-up, job moves, promotion, appraisal vs each PME's choices	Productivity, retention, hires, exits in volunteer pilot firms (Directions A, C), vs a comparison group
Consent now	490 of 1,020 PMEs (48%) agreed to one short (about 5-minute) survey in 6–12 months (Feb–Aug 2027)	None: the employer survey asked no re-contact question
Partner roles	**NTUC:** reach members beyond online panels; **MOM:** linkage only with fresh consent, under its data rules	**SNEF:** recruit fresh volunteer member firms; **MOM:** firm linkage only with consent
Templates	Maestas et al.: 56% matched up to 3 years later (validity)	Trip.com hybrid trial: quits fell 7.20% to 4.80%; German LPP: consented employer–employee linkage, six waves 2012–2024

Consent scope: 490 PMEs consented to one short survey in 6–12 months; further waves, linkage and firm-side work require fresh consent.

Consenters lean to caregivers (52.6% vs 39.7% agreed).

Summary

Backup index

Backup B49

Direction A: test the compressed week

Direction: A **Strength:** moderate; operating costs unmeasured

The evidence

PMEs would give up about 7% of pay for it; employers would require about 11% (interval 0–21%): no detectable gap. 15% of surveyed firms offer it, more often with a written policy (18% vs 9%). It was the cheaper option in 83% (PME) and 92% (employer) of its pairs.

Owner and first step

SNEF, with volunteer member firms: put it on the written menu and test it in a bounded, evaluated pilot (checklist). **NTUC:** co-design safeguards. **TAFEP:** guidance.

Builds on

TAFEP and IHRP resources; SNEF guidance on FWA requests.

What it is not

Not shorter hours (same hours, four longer days), a mandate or a case for lower pay; not shown to be costless.

What to watch

Output, coverage, rostering, fatigue; take-up where available (31%).

◂ Directions ◂ Puzzle

Backup index

Backup B50

Direction B: match arrangements to roles

Direction: B **Strength:** exploratory; preliminary associations

The evidence

Where most roles need presence, firms would require a pay cut of about 49% for 1–2 WFH days, against 3% where only some or few do (PMEs would give up about 7%; PMEs were not asked about presence). A compressed week: 6% against 11%, not significantly different. Preliminary.

Owner and first step

Firms, with SNEF: review which tasks need presence; start with 1–2 WFH days where roles allow; a compressed week may fit where WFH does not; use flexi-load where fewer hours, not location, address the need. Job Redesign+: up to 70% of qualifying costs for SMEs, 50% for others. **MOM:** PTRG review.

Associations; asked after the choices. Flexi-load.

Builds on

EWTP (Mar 2026), linked by MOM to FWAs.

What it is not

Not one-size-fits-all; not a quota.

What to watch

Fairness to staff without FWAs (second challenge, 24% of firms with $\leq$200 staff; productivity 26%); part-time access (COS 2026: under half who needed it got it).

◂ Directions ◂ On-site needs

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Direction C: reach juniors and support managers and HR

Direction: C **Strength:** exploratory; descriptive and associations, the effect of training is untested

The evidence

At least one of five arrangements available: 80% of junior professionals, 85% of middle and 94% of senior management; in use: 66%, 72%, 80%. Use given access is similar (82–85%). Know the key provisions of the Guidelines: 29%, 52%, 77%; 45% of PMEs fear a career penalty (36% of juniors, 52% of seniors). Most FWAs arrive through company policy (43%), not a request (30%). Employers' concern levels do not reliably change the pay cut.

Owner and first step

Firms, with MOM and NTUC outreach: tell juniors about the Guidelines through company policy. **TAFEP, NTUC, firms:** train HR and managers on requests, with volunteer firms.

Builds on

Company policies; MOM and NTUC channels; TAFEP, IHRP and SNEF resources; 63% of employers know the Guidelines.

What it is not

Not a new entitlement or reporting duty; not shown that training changes appraisal or use.

What to watch

Access and familiarity among juniors; take-up among those with access; whether career worry falls and use rises.

Descriptive and associations; concern items were asked after the choices (see by level).

◂ Directions ◂ By level

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Measure what is missing: draft survey items

The gap

Firms need not report requests to MOM; in MOM's survey, 18.5% of those needing an FWA made a formal request (2024). MOM publishes request rates, not reasons. Our survey had no why-not item, and our request item was partly misread. Of PMEs reporting a request, about 4% were declined (a lower bound) and 32% partly approved.

Owner and first step

MOM (MRSD), with NTUC and SNEF: check its survey, then add the items not yet asked. Not a new reporting duty for firms; not an evaluation of the Guidelines.

First step (employees)

1. **Why not ask:** if you needed an FWA but did not request one, why not? (career concern; did not know how; expected refusal; automatic)
2. **Outcome:** approved as requested / with changes / declined.
3. Formal request: add "applies automatically".
4. Guidelines awareness; would flexible work affect your career?

Later, if partners agree (establishments)

5. Any formal FWA request in the past 12 months?
6. Share approved as requested, with changes, or declined?
7. Roles needing on-site presence: which arrangements are offered?

Draft for MRSD, to check against EWC and CoE questionnaires; item 1 appears new.

◂ Directions ◂ Barriers

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